

Nuclear Deterrent

(Sana's POV)

In the geopolitics of a mana-saturated world, concepts like "Mutually Assured Destruction" had become obsolete. We didn't need nuclear warheads sitting in silos; we had Charlie. His very existence had become our nuclear deterrent, a silence that kept the noisy threats of other nations at bay. Usually, our exterminator would simply vanish, erase the target from existence, and return before his coffee went cold.

But this time, the silence was stretching too long.

"The Sixth Calamity Class," I muttered, the wind whipping my hair as I sat perched atop the spire of the Burj Khalifa.

The reports claimed this new threat possessed mana *quality* far superior to the "First Hero." To the uninitiated, that sounded like a death sentence for us. But they didn't understand the semantics of power. The "First Hero" was a title Charlie abandoned eons ago. He had discarded "Vampire King" shortly after that. Now, he operated under the singularity of a single, absolute title: **The Strongest**.

Comparing the Calamity to the "First Hero" was like comparing a modern railgun to a musket. It was a category error. If Charlie wasn't back, it wasn't because he *couldn't* kill the target. It was because he *wouldn't*.

I engaged my **Omnipresence**, warping the space-time coordinates around the spire to ensure total privacy. No satellite, no mana-scope, and certainly no human eye could perceive me here. It had been so long since I ceased to be human. Charlie and I... we were the originals. Test Subject #1 and #2. God's attempt to see if mortals could execute divine will.

But Subject #1 went haywire. Charlie shattered the mold, twisted his humanity into something incomprehensible, and left me behind—intact, human, and infinitely guilty.

"I will not recall that past!" I shouted, the memory stinging more than the altitude.

I stood on the needle-thin edge of the skyscraper, 828 meters above the desert floor. The air was thin, but for a being like me, physics was just a suggestion. I leaned forward and let gravity take me.

The free fall was instant. The wind roared, tearing at my clothes, the acceleration hitting 9.8 m/s^2 . It was a relaxing embrace, a brief surrender to the laws of nature before I broke them.

As the tarmac of the road below rushed up to meet me, I didn't slow down. I simply *shifted*.

Snap.

The blistering heat of Dubai vanished. The roar of the city died.

"Wow, the view is amazing," I said, exhaling a plume of white mist.

I blinked, and I was standing on the summit of Mount Everest. The transition was seamless—no portal, no tear, just the instantaneous rewriting of my location in the universe. The snow-capped peaks of Nepal stretched out before me, bathed in a mystical silence.

"It must be nice to be a yeti," I mused, enjoying the solitude.

I could have seen this view from my bedroom using **Omnipresence**, but that was just data. This... the biting cold, the thin air... this was reality. And reality was where I needed to operate, because my powers were failing me where it mattered most.

"Should I go check on him?" I asked the freezing wind.

The Pentarchy was growing restless. Behind closed doors, they were developing a coup. I had seen the blueprints—a "God-Killer" containment unit designed to trap a being by siphoning the collective powers of every reincarnated hero. They planned to bind Charlie to his original sword, sealing him like a Jinn in a lamp.

It was a cute plan. Futile, but cute.

Even if their machine worked, I would tear it apart with my bare hands to ensure Charlie remained unharmed. But to stop them, I needed Charlie back.

"Why haven't you returned?" I focused my mind, trying to locate his signature.

Nothing.

It was the one barrier I couldn't cross. Charlie and I had blocked each other's magical signatures ages ago. Or rather, his **Chrono Destinatus**—the ability that preserved his timeline and his fragile mental health—involutionarily scrubbed him from my radar.

My **Omnipresence** doesn't see the world; it reads the pages of Fate. And Charlie? Charlie burns the book. He is unbound by Fate, a variable that refuses to be written.

I began to pace across the snow, drawing a plan of action in my mind.

If the Sixth Calamity were dead, Charlie would be here, complaining about the paperwork. If he wasn't here, and he hadn't used **Cosmic Deicide** to wipe the enemy from existence, there was only one logical conclusion.

"The Bridge," I realized, stopping cold.

The bridge between worlds was corroding. Charlie, in his essence, is pure Destruction. He cannot repair; he can only unmake. If the bridge was damaged, he couldn't force his way back without shattering the pathway permanently. And he couldn't use **Cosmic Deicide** on the Sixth Calamity because...

"He needs them," I whispered, the realization hitting me with the force of an avalanche. "He needs the Calamity alive, or at least their mana, to fix the bridge."

He was stranded, waiting for a mechanic while holding a sledgehammer.

"I need to go to the First World," I decided, the snow crunching beneath my boots as I turned toward the horizon.

If I told the Pentarchy this logic, they would call it an excuse to save a monster. But they didn't know Charlie. They only knew the weapon. I knew the tragedy.

I raised my hand, mana coalescing around my fingers, preparing to rip a hole not just in space, but in the vibrational frequency of the universe itself.

"Hang on, Charlie," I muttered, my eyes glowing with the light of absolute knowledge. I don't think he knows that sana is the code name of the girl he spend his childhood with but no better surprise right.